

officials were eager to offer the people a wide range of events to choose from—blood and guts at the arena or laughs and hisses at the theater!

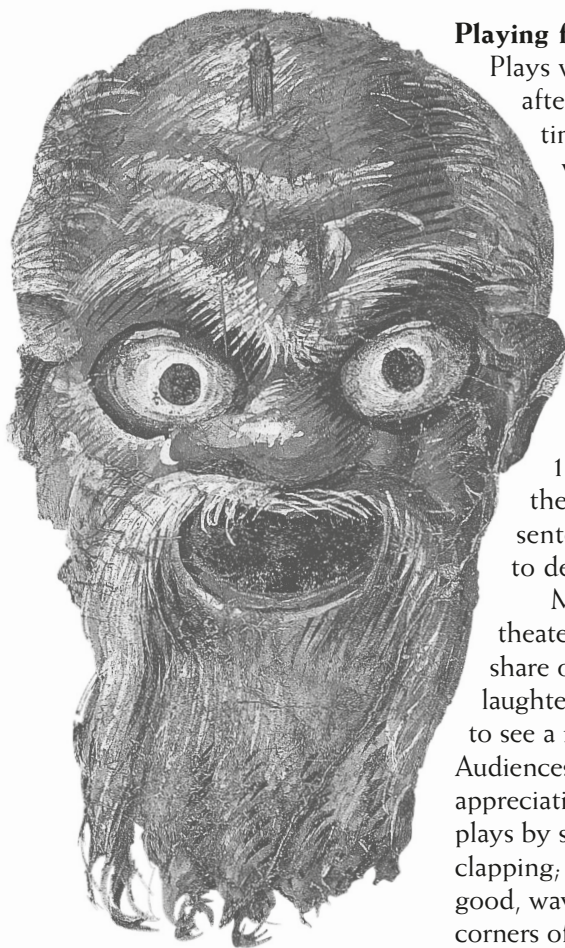
At first sight, a theater, such as Rome's 12,000-seat Theater of Marcellus, looks like half an

arena. But the way you should really see it is the other way around—an arena is like two theaters joined together to make a circular (or oval) building. This is why an arena is known as an amphitheater, which means "double-theater."

Playing for laughs

Plays were performed in the afternoons, at the same time that gladiators were hacking lumps off each other in the arena. While theatergoers were booing a bad actor or pelting him with apples (never tomatoes, which didn't exist in Europe until the 1500s), people at the games might be sentencing a gladiator to death!

Mind you, Roman theaters enjoyed their share of side-splitting, too—laughter that is. People loved to see a rib-tickling comedy. Audiences showed their appreciation for well-performed plays by snapping their fingers; clapping; and, if it was really good, waving handkerchiefs and corners of their clothes. Serious plays, called tragedies, were just as popular, but without the laughs (maybe a few tears).



ACTORS WORE MASKS THAT LET THE AUDIENCE KNOW WHETHER THE PLAY WAS A TRAGEDY OR A COMEDY. THIS MASK WAS WORN IN A COMEDY.